



» COVER PACKAGE INTERVIEW

« Sports has given me a chance to serve India again, something I thought I had lost after my injury in the Army »

HOKATO HOTOZHE SEMA

Winning a bronze medal in Men's Shot Put F57 at the Paris Paralympics was the most important moment of my life. But some of the hardest lessons came afterwards.

What makes that medal even more special is how close I came to missing it. Just before the Games, I suffered a bout of dengue. As soon as I recovered, I caught chicken pox three days before flying out to Paris. I was so ill I couldn't train at all after landing.

Honestly, I didn't believe I would win a medal until the moment I stepped onto the field. Then, something shifted inside me — a voice told me I wasn't going home without one. Despite being far from my best, I threw a Personal Best of 14.66m. That bronze medal proved to me that I could overcome physical limitations and still make my country proud.

When I returned from Paris, everything changed. Suddenly, I was being recognised everywhere, invited to events and honoured with the Arjuna Award. As the first athlete



After losing my leg, I used to cover up my stump because I was ashamed. Now I wear shorts everywhere. If people stare, I let them. I tell others with disabilities: never be shy of them. Turn them into strength.